was of great political significance. In the letter, he had also opined that the chief minister would be ‘very upset’ to learn that the project was not viable. In addition, Seth also doubted the capacity of the state government to raise funds for the project and demanded it provide concrete evidence of its capacity and willingness to ensure the uninterrupted flow of funds. In doing so, Seth stirred a hornets’ nest.

After being briefed on Seth’s opinion, Chief Minister Basu immediately asked for a highly confidential meeting with JRD and Ratan on 13 January 1993 in Bombay. As Seth was now not seen as a supporter of the project, he was not invited. He took this as a personal affront. The meeting did not, however, take place as scheduled.

It was held on 28 January, in Tata Centre, Calcutta. Seth was again kept out of the discussions. But on the same day, he wrote to JRD and Ratan reiterating that the project was not feasible, that they should brief Basu on these lines and a decision on the continued involvement of the Tata Group in the project should be deferred. Ratan was not, however, willing to abandon the project without exhausting all avenues.

The state government also expected Ratan to steer the project to its logical conclusion. They had nominated him to the project’s board in 1991 and he was seen more as the government’s representative. During the meeting, it was decided that the Tatas would continue their association with the project, while they searched for another partner. It was also decided that if they did not succeed in the effort, both the state government and the Tata Group ‘would jointly decide to consider shelving or deferring the project as amicable partners’. The two parties also agreed to review the situation again at a meeting in early March.

The search for a third partner, however, drew a blank. In view of this situation, on 26 April, JRD addressed Jyoti Basu, informing him of how their efforts at finding a partner had not succeeded. Given this bleak situation, in an informal meeting of the board members of Tata Tea, on 18 June, both Tata Tea and Tata Chemicals (companies led by Seth) expressed their intention to withdraw from Haldia.

Various newspapers carried different stories. Some suggested that Bombay House would even make internal changes to stay in the project and that Ratan would go ahead with it, even if Tata Tea and Tata Chemicals did decide to withdraw. Ratan could step in through the companies he headed (TISCO and TELCO) to fill the breach, wrote a leading daily.